



A Story on the Platter

Food at Naar restaurant



If you were to take a three-hour flight, then rent a cab and drive for another two hours off the beaten path—off-any kind of path—to reach a spot in the middle of nowhere to have a meal, imagine what that meal would have to be like. In a sylvan quarter on the edge of a pine forest near Kasauli in Himachal Pradesh lies Naar, a 16-cover restaurant, where celebrated chef Prateek Sadhu serves a 15-course degustation menu, with sides of audacity and genius.

Naar—Kashmiri for fire—opened in October 2023 as India's 'first' destination restaurant, "where people travel for a culinary experience" and not just food, in the chef's words. Far from the trappings of modernist global Indian cuisine—the foie gras kebabs and truffle naans—Sadhu and his team of chefs are taking the road less travelled to develop a micro-cuisine story which he terms as "Himalayan forward". Elements of regional cuisines of the Himalayas from Kashmir to Arunachal Pradesh—the traditional recipes and food staples; hyper local produce; grains; and herbs grown or foraged there—are curated and reinterpreted in modernist avatars. Like the flame-crisped Himalayan trout fillet served with a chilli-mustard emulsion over Ladakhi khambir bread. Then there is the pork belly, smoked for eight hours and skewered with tender pine branches on a table grill; each bite of melting meat is tinged with the tart of the pine sap.

Not just the food, but its geography too is served, plated on leaves, bark and even river stones. The solitude of the valley facing the restaurant, and the wafts of pine-scented breeze provide the perfect sensorial calm to unravel and delight in the layering of flavours. Reservations (at ₹6,500, plus taxes, per person) open a month in advance and fill up in days. This year, *Time* magazine put Naar in its list of the 100 best places to 'visit'; very appropriate. To describe it as a 'best place to eat' would be to limit it.

